

The Washington Post

Prices may vary in areas outside metropolitan Washington.

SU V1 V2 V3 V4



Sunny, breezy 72/46 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 66/47 **B6**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, MARCH 11, 2025 • \$4

Ex-official recounts DOGE blitz of agency

Lawsuit says appointees sought and exposed key data from Social Security

BY LISA REIN

They came in aggressively, a former official who witnessed Elon Musk's team take over the Social Security Administration said, demanding access to sensitive taxpayer data and refusing briefings on how the agency ensures the accuracy of its benefit systems. They recklessly exposed data in unsecured areas outside Social Security offices, the official said, potentially disclosing personally identifiable information on almost every American to people not authorized to see it.

And representatives sent by the U.S. DOGE Service refused to explain why they needed taxpayer information that is protected by law, the former official said. Despite their status as political appointees, the secretive members of the cost-cutting group overseen by Musk ignored the normal chain of command, instead communicating directly with DOGE.

These and other allegations are included in a sweeping declaration filed as part of a federal lawsuit Friday from Tiffany Flick, the agency's acting chief of staff until she was forced out in mid-February.

Flick describes a fast and tension-filled takeover of the agency and its sensitive data systems by

SEE DOGE ON A5

Disgust at Musk: Democrats tap anger to motivate their voters. **A4**

Preparing for talks, Ukraine battles on

Hounded in Kursk and at home, Kyiv hopes to repair relations with U.S.

BY CATHERINE BELTON
AND KOSTIANTYN KHUDOV

KYIV — Ukrainian forces battled to stave off fierce Russian attacks both inside Russia and along Ukraine's front lines, as the country's officials prepared Monday for high-stakes talks in Saudi Arabia with an increasingly skeptical ally, the United States.

Ukraine hopes the talks, set to begin Tuesday, will restore relations after a bruising week in which President Donald Trump paused the provision of military aid and intelligence sharing vital for Kyiv to repel Russian attacks. After Russian advances in the Kursk region, where Ukrainians hold a sliver of Russian territory, the Ukrainian military said the situation was stabilizing.

Ukrainian officials will seek to convince the U.S. delegation that they are ready for a swift end to the war, and they are set to present a case for a partial ceasefire after Ukrainian President Volodymyr

SEE UKRAINE ON A9

Aid: Trump may resume support if peace talks go well, Rubio says. **A9**



PAUL RATJE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

In danger, then limbo, in Mexico

The businessman arrived at the border in a freshly pressed shirt and polished leather shoes. In his backpack were the records detailing how he'd been kidnapped, sodomized and stuffed in a closet by members of a Mexican cartel.

JC walked to the midpoint of the international bridge that connected the industrial Mexican city known for its violent past and the United States, one that has drawn droves of migrants seeking a future in America.

Days before, President Donald Trump had taken office and quickly shuttered the border to almost everyone who didn't have a visa or a U.S. passport. JC, who spoke with The Washington Post on the condition that his full name not be used,

A man escaped the cartel that kidnapped him, but when he got to the U.S. border, he was told there's 'no more asylum'

BY ARELIS R. HERNÁNDEZ
IN CIUDAD JUÁREZ, MEXICO

A woman from Honduras walks through the courtyard of a migrant shelter in Ciudad Juárez, Mexico.

out of fear his assailants will target him, hoped to convince immigration officials that he needed to be let in anyway. There were still-healing scars on his face, wrists and legs. He had records from Mexican prosecutors corroborating the cartel's savagery. His life depended on it.

As he approached, he said, U.S. immigration officials quickly turned him away.

"There is no more asylum," he recalled them saying, minutes before Mexican officers stationed on the bridge chased him away.

The right to seek protection from persecution in one's homeland has been a bedrock principle in the United States since the aftermath of World War II. By law, anyone who reaches U.S. soil and

SEE ASYLUM ON A6

Standing united, D.C. officials try to stop 'devastating' cuts

BY MEAGAN FLYNN
AND JENNY GATHRIGHT

D.C. Mayor Muriel E. Bowser (D) and almost every D.C. lawmaker stood on the lawn of the U.S. Capitol on Monday and implored House Republicans to reverse course on the \$1.1 billion in cuts to D.C. services they said the GOP's spending bill would cause to its \$21 billion local budget if

Nearly all city lawmakers head to Hill to avert \$1.1 billion hit to budget

the measure passed — a rare show of solidarity across all corners of District government that underscored the depth of city

officials' fears.

The GOP's stopgap funding bill, called a continuing resolution, would treat D.C. as a federal agency and force the city to revert to fiscal 2024 spending levels for the next six months, amounting to the effective cancellation of the city's active 2025 budget.

Bowser — joined by members of her Cabinet, Del. Eleanor Holmes Norton (D) and almost

the entire D.C. Council — warned that the city would have to find more than \$1 billion in immediate, across-the-board cuts affecting every area of D.C. government, probably including teachers, law enforcement officers and other critical-front line workers.

Bowser called the prospect "devastating." There could be immediate layoffs and cuts to city services that touch Washington-

nians' everyday lives, officials stressed.

"There's no way, to cut that kind of money in the time that we have this fiscal year, not to affect police, not to affect teachers and not to affect some of the basic government services that allow

SEE BUDGET ON A14

Vouchers: Private schools would get billions under GOP plan. **A3**



ASTRID RIECKEN/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

A sign of the times is taken apart

Workers began dismantling Black Lives Matter Plaza a week after Mayor Muriel E. Bowser announced its "evolution." It was built during President Donald Trump's first term, but a GOP congressman last week introduced a bill threatening D.C.'s transportation funding if the mayor didn't erase or rename it.

Pivot to West Bank has Israeli settlers boasting

Far-right leaders say they had long lobbied for military to apply its Gaza tactics to the territory

BY GERRY SHIH,
MIRIAM BERGER,
HEIDI LEVINE
AND CLAIRE PARKER

TULKARM, WEST BANK — Israel's soldiers have destroyed entire city blocks and bulldozed roads. Its drones fire at cars and buildings thought to be sheltering militants. Its tanks and snipers watch over deserted neighborhoods where thousands of civilians lived before their water and electricity lines were severed.

This is not Gaza, but the newest front in Israel's war: the West Bank.

More than a year after Hamas launched its Oct. 7, 2023, attack on Israel and provoked a war with it in Gaza, the Israeli military is shifting its firepower and attention to another Palestinian terri-

tory. Israeli officials say their offensive in the occupied West Bank — the largest such military operation there in decades — is needed to roll back a growing militant presence in the cities of Jenin, Tulkarm and Nablus. These officials point to an uptick in shootings and stabbings and a suspected bomb attack on empty buses outside Tel Aviv last month as evidence of a terrorist threat.

But many Palestinians and some Israeli analysts say the scale and intensity of the operation — which humanitarian groups say has displaced nearly 40,000 Palestinian residents in two months — are vastly out of proportion to the actual threat. And in its timing, tactics and public promotion, these observers see a campaign driven not just by security con-

SEE WEST BANK ON A10

IN THE NEWS

Frustration with FEMA In North Carolina, people bash the agency online, and many awaiting repairs say they feel abandoned. **A18**

Jan. 6 pardons In seven cases, the Justice Department has argued that separate criminal actions uncovered by the riot investigation are covered by the clemency order. **B1**

THE NATION

The Trump administration celebrated the arrest of a prominent pro-Palestinian activist. **A4**
The Supreme Court will review a challenge to a ban on "conversion therapy" for minors. **A7**

THE WORLD

Tuesday's vote in Greenland may offer clues to how the territory sees its future. **A8**
Syria's interim government reached a landmark deal with Kurdish-led authorities. **A11**

THE ECONOMY

Automakers seeking to start banks are hoping for a more receptive audience in the Trump administration. **A12**
Dozens of grants for research on vaccine hesitancy and uptake will be canceled or limited, a National Institutes of Health email said. **A13**

THE REGION

An armed man from Indiana was critically wounded by Secret Service near the White House on Sunday, authorities said. **B1**
Rat poison is sickening and killing an increasing number of birds and mammals in the District, a study found. **B1**

STYLE

Between political anxiety and DOGE employees working through the night, Washington is sleep-deprived. **C1**

HEALTH & SCIENCE
The "placebo effect" is real, according to a growing body of research, and can help alleviate pain and other problems. **E1**

BUSINESS NEWS.....A12
COMICS.....C7
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A15
TELEVISION.....C6
WORLD NEWS.....A8

CONTENT © 2025
The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54152

